Cancer Incidence in Children and Young People in England

A briefing for public health and policy audiences

Data Source: NHS NDRS Cancer Incidence Dashboard · ICD-10 C00-C97 excl. C44 · Age group: 0–24 · England only
Full project available at *github.com/Gil6346/cyp-cancer-incidence-england*
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Approximately **7,700** children and young people (CYP) are diagnosed with cancer in England each year. **Blood cancer** accounts for over a third of all cases and is the most common type at every age from infancy to young adulthood. When regional data is adjusted for population size, the North East has the highest cancer burden — a pattern invisible in raw case counts, which are dominated by larger southern regions.

Blood Cancer and Young Adulthood Age Group Dominate

- Blood cancer (35.1%) and Brain cancer (19.6%) together account for over half of all CYP cancer cases in England between 2013 and 2022. Cancer incidence rises sharply with age: the 20-24 age group accounts for 36% of all cases — nearly double the next largest group. The composition of cancer types shifts meaningfully across age groups, with Skin cancer emerging as the second most common type in young adults aged 20-24, displacing Brain cancer from that position.

Rising Trends in Blood Cancer and Endocrine Glands

- National CYP cancer case counts were broadly stable across the decade, ranging between approximately 7,200 and 8,200 cases per year. A 6.4% decline in 2020 is consistent with COVID-19 diagnostic disruption, with partial recovery by 2022 still below 2019 levels. Skin cancer showed the largest absolute decline (-220 cases comparing 2013 to 2022), while blood cancer showed the largest increase (+196 cases), followed by Endocrine glands excluding brain (+142 cases), consistent with nationally recognised trends in thyroid cancer incidence among young adults.

North East Has Highest Population-Adjusted Cancer Burden

- Raw cancer case counts are highest in South East England and London (11,710 and 11,676 cases respectively), reflecting larger populations rather than higher cancer risk. When adjusted for population size, the North East records the highest age-specific incidence rate at 21.6 per 100,000 — despite ranking last by raw case count. The overall range of population-adjusted rates across regions is narrow (18.4-21.6 per 100,000), suggesting that most regional variation in case counts is explained by population size rather than genuine differences in cancer incidence.

Recommendations

- Prioritise targeted outreach and early presentation awareness for Blood cancer and Brain cancer in CYP, where these types account for the first and second highest case volumes at every age group studied.
- Investigate the elevated population-adjusted incidence rate in the North East (21.6 per 100,000 — the highest of any region) to determine whether this reflects genuine epidemiological differences, diagnostic practice variation, data artefact, or socioeconomic/deprivation factors — and consider whether current service capacity reflects this burden.
- Monitor the observed rise in Endocrine gland cancers (excluding brain) among young adults, which recorded the second largest absolute increase of any cancer type across the study period (+142 cases, 2013–2022), to determine whether this trend represents a sustained epidemiological shift requiring service response.

Data Sources and Limitations

- Analysis uses NHS NDRS Cancer Incidence Dashboard data (England only, 2013–2022).
- Cancer type analysis uses NDRS Cancer Group classification; regional rate analysis uses ICD-10 C00-C97 excl. C44 (age-specific rate per 100,000).
- Regional boundaries reflect pre-2019 NHS England legacy structure (nine regions).
- Count-based analysis used throughout national and regional NDRS data due to high rate suppression.
- A visible decline in 2020 registrations likely reflects COVID-19 diagnostic disruption rather than genuine incidence change.
- Ecological analysis — findings describe population-level patterns and cannot be applied to individuals.
- Data lag: 2022 figures represent the most recently available data at time of analysis.

Supporting Charts

Figure 1: Top 3 Cancer Types by Age Group

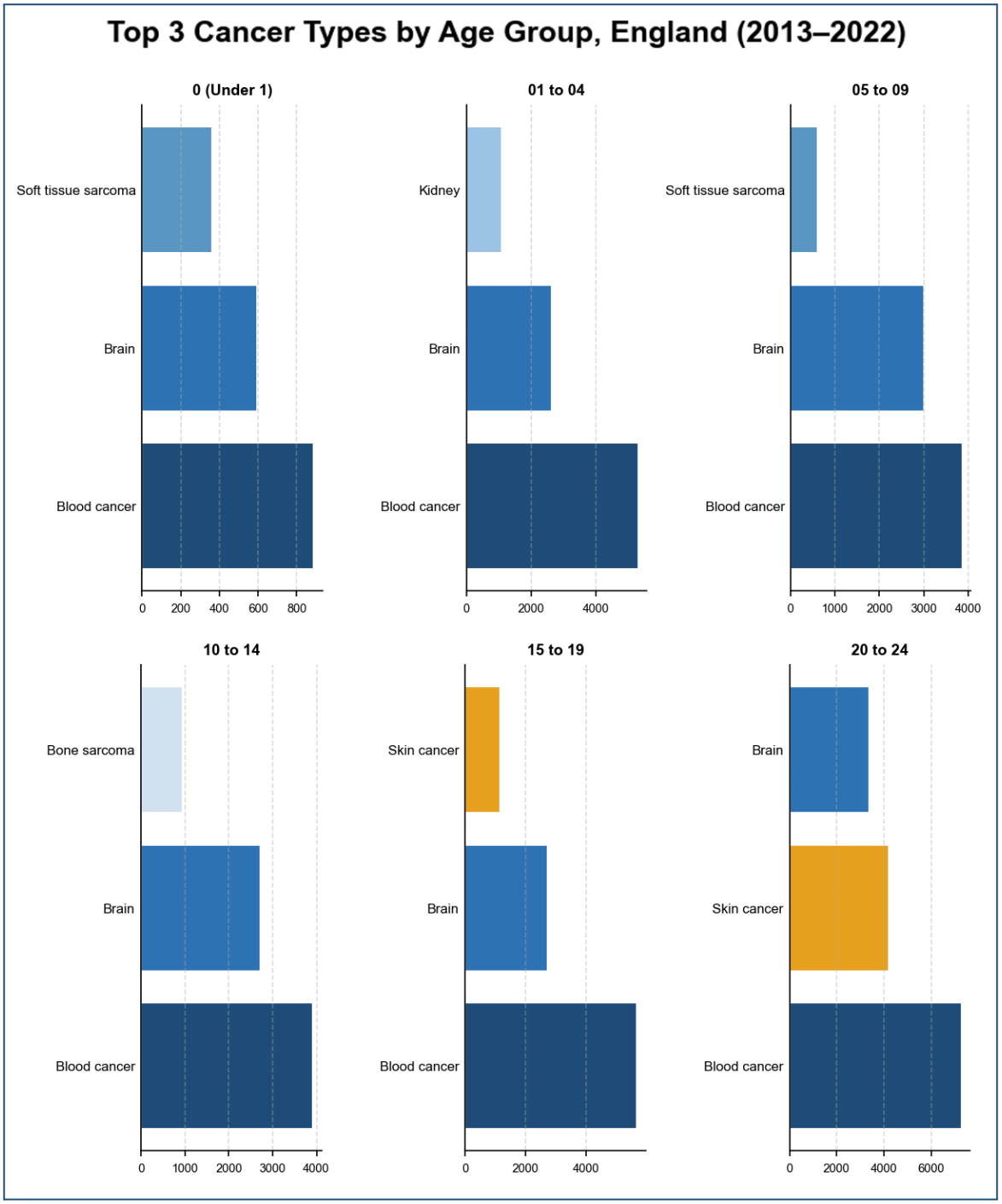


Figure 2: Regional comparison between raw case count and population-adjusted rate

